Orphans and Archetypes: Placing Unassigned Hittite Ritual Fragments in Their Traditions

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Abstract

Thousands of Hittite ritual and festival fragments cannot be assigned to a composition because no parallel passage survives. Laroche's residual category CTH 470 and the recently digitised EBo fragments hold 3,033 such manuscripts in the TLHdig 0.3 release, with a median of 10 legible words in CTH 470 and 4 among the EBo. We ask whether the words of a fragment and the way they are spelled can place it in a ritual or festival tradition, and how far such a placement can be trusted. Ten reference traditions are taken from the studies that argued for them and mapped to Laroche's CTH numbers. Nearest-centroid assignment over tf-idf features of word forms and sign sequences returns 84% of held-out manuscripts to their tradition (majority baseline 30%), and 57 of 78 compositions held out whole return to their scholarly group. A margin calibrated on held-out fragments of matching size lets the method abstain; it places 847 of 2,026 orphans at an expected precision of 80%. Splitting each decision exactly over its features shows that traditions are identified by what is written, above all agents, deities, realia and foreign-language words, and hardly by how it is spelled; common particles make up 47% of the similarity but 11% of the decision. Code and outputs are released, and every number in the paper is generated from them.

1 Introduction

Emmanuel Laroche's *Catalogue des textes hittites* (Laroche, 1971) gave every Hittite composition a number, and with it a place: rituals in one block, festivals in another, texts in Hattian, Luwian and Hurrian in blocks of their own. What could not be placed went into residual categories. CTH 470, "fragments of rituals", is the largest of them, and it has grown with every volume of hand copies since 1971. The Mainz Hethitologie-Portal keeps Laroche's numbers as a shared address system while moving fragments after joins (Košak et al., 2026; Košak, 2026). The digitisation of the EBo fragments in TLHdig 0.3 (Müller et al., 2026) adds 1,151 more manuscripts with a median of 4 legible words, most of them filed under two further residual numbers, CTH 832 and CTH 670.

A philologist assigns such a fragment through a parallel: a duplicate, or a close parallel passage in an identified composition. For most of these orphans that route is closed by definition. We ask instead whether the content of a fragment, its words and their spellings, can point to its tradition, and how far such a pointer can be trusted. Put this way, the task is attribution, and two known weaknesses of attribution apply with full force: accuracy falls with the length of the sample (Eder, 2015), and a classifier with a closed set of candidates always names one of them, even when the true source is not among them (Koppel et al., 2011). A placement is also only useful to a philologist who can check it, which requires knowing what it rests on.

Gordin et al. (2025) mapped about 1,000 Hurrian and Luwian festival manuscripts with tf-idf and t-SNE and proposed, as a next step, to test which word groups carry the signal. We turn that exploration into assignment, with explicit baselines, held-out evaluation and a rule for when not to assign. Our contributions are:

1. a reference of ten ritual and festival traditions, each defined by the study that argued for it and mapped to Laroche's CTH numbers, with the ranges that no study claims set aside as test sets (Section 3);

2. an evaluation that holds out manuscripts and whole compositions, so that the scholarly groupings themselves, and one contested attribution, are tested; that follows accuracy down to fragment size; and that calibrates a margin for abstention (Section 5);

3. an exact decomposition of each decision over word categories and writing layers, which separates what is written from how it is written and shows how much rests on common particles such as *nu* (Section 5.3);

4. a placement of 847 orphans, each with the features it rests on, as leads for verification on the tablet.

2 Background

Traditions and the catalogue. Laroche sorted by genre first and by language second, while later scholarship defines a ritual tradition by the origin of its practitioners, its cult and its ritual language. One tradition therefore ends up scattered over several CTH ranges. The Kizzuwatna rituals occupy CTH 471–500, but the ritual of the Kizzuwatnean Old Woman Maštigga is filed with the named practitioners at CTH 404 (Miller, 2004); the rituals of the AZU priest (CTH 701) sit in the Hurrian block (Salvini and Wegner, 1986); and the named-practitioner rituals of CTH 390–469 come from Arzawa, the Lower Land and Kizzuwatna alike (Christiansen, 2006; Bawanypeck, 2005). The festivals have been regrouped by cult geography (Gordin et al., 2025; Görke, 2022; Trameri, 2025) and, in the Hethitische Festrituale project (HFR), into edition modules such as the Luwian and the Palaic festivals (Rieken and Schwemer, 2026; Görke, 2020).

Scribal habit and attribution. Hittite scribes copied, excerpted and re-edited ritual texts over two centuries, and their habits of logographic writing, plene spelling and sign choice vary with date, school and individual (Gordin, 2015; Weeden, 2011; van den Hout, 2009; Waal, 2015). Whether a habit marks a tradition, a circle of scribes or a date is therefore a question to test, not an assumption. Stylometry supplies frequency-based representations, distance measures and protocols with held-out evaluation (Burrows, 2002; Juola, 2008; Stamatatos, 2009), and open-set recognition the means to reject a sample that fits no candidate (Scheirer et al., 2013).

Computational work on cuneiform. Machine learning on cuneiform has addressed transliteration and translation (Gordin et al., 2020; Yavasan and Gordin, 2025), language and dialect identification (Jauhiainen et al., 2019), the matching of fragments to known compositions by sign sequences (Simonjetz et al., 2024), and palaeographic style (Yugay et al., 2024). Fragment matching finds a known text; it does not place a fragment whose parallels are lost, and all of these studies are closed-set. We know of no published study that uses content features to assign Hittite fragments to religious traditions, or that asks when a fragment fits none of them.

3 Data

Corpus. We use the TLHdig Beta 0.3 release (Müller et al., 2026), converted to one row per word following Yavasan and Gordin (2025). Each word carries its normalised form, its transliteration split into signs, its language and, where the editors provide one, a morphological analysis. The release is downloaded by script and checked by its checksum, so the word table can be rebuilt from the public data alone. As in Gordin et al. (2025), reference manuscripts must have at least 17 legible words. The editors' analyses do not cover the whole release: the Luwian rituals (CTH 758–763) have none, and many other rituals lack them. The main model reads analysed words, so in its reference the Luwian rituals have 10 manuscripts and the western rituals 11; Section 5.2 repeats the evaluation on spellings alone with every manuscript.

Orphans. Orphans are all CTH 470 manuscripts and all EBo manuscripts, wherever TLHdig files them, 3,033 in all. CTH 670 and 832, where most EBo fragments are filed, are pools of orphans, not traditions. Of the 2,899 orphans in the CTH ranges we load, 2,026 have at least five legible words and are placed (median 7 words). Orphans never enter the reference.

Reference traditions. Each tradition is defined by the study that argued for it (Table 1). The Hurrian festival groups follow Table 3 of Gordin et al. (2025). Its single Luwian group is split as HFR splits it, into the festivals of Ištanuwa and Lallupiya and those of Ḫuwaššanna, and HFR's Palaic festivals are added (Rieken and Schwemer, 2026). The ritual traditions are the Kizzuwatna rituals as delimited by Miller (2004); the western rituals, that is, the augur rituals (Bawanypeck, 2005) and those whose colophon names Arzawa or Ḫapalla as the practitioner's home; the Luwian rituals of Puriyanni, Kuwattalla and Šilalluḫi (CTH 758–763), which Yakubovich and Mouton (2023) place in the Lower Land rather than in Kizzuwatna; and the Hattian cult layer of Klinger (1996), whose texts we take from the citations of his study in the Mainz Konkordanz

Tradition	CTH	Defining studies	n
Kizzuwatna and Lower Land (Hurr.)	628, 699–700, 711–713, 719, 722	Gordin et al. (2025) Table 3; Wegner and Salvini (1991)	318
Syro-Mesopotamia (Hurr.)	698, 701, 714–715, 721	Gordin et al. (2025) Table 3; Salvini and Wegner (1986)	167
Mixed (Hurr., Syr., Luw.)	704–706, 720	Gordin et al. (2025) Table 3	200
Ištanuwa and Lallupiya festivals	665, 771–773	Rieken and Schwemer (2026); Görke (2020); Hutter (2003)	52
Ḫuwaššanna festivals	690–694	Rieken and Schwemer (2026); Hutter (2003)	189
Palaic festivals	750–754	Rieken and Schwemer (2026); Görke (2020)	34
Kizzuwatna rituals	404, 471–499	Miller (2004); Strauß (2006); Görke (2010)	165
Arzawa (western) rituals	394, 402, 406, 410, 425, 433	Bawanypeck (2005); colophons	11
Luwian rituals (Lower Land)	758–763	Yakubovich and Mouton (2023)	10
Hattian cult layer	591, 627, 725–729, 731–746, 820–821	Klinger (1996)	480

Table 1: Reference traditions, the studies that define them, and the number of reference manuscripts with 17 or more legible words. CTH numbers follow the Portal CTH (Košak et al., 2026).

(Košak, 2026). The Ambazzi rituals (CTH 391, 429, 463) show Luwian influence but no stated link to Arzawa (Christiansen, 2006), so they stay outside the western group; Section 5.1 tests that decision.

Two sets leave the reference and are placed like orphans: the texts of CTH 390–469 that no defining study claims, and CTH 500, "fragments of festival and incantation rituals from Kizzuwatna", which is a running list of fragments rather than a composition. For CTH 701, the subgroups a–f of Salvini and Wegner (1986) and the script dates come from the Konkordanz and serve as partial ground truth.

4 Method

Figure 1 follows one orphan, KBo 41.22, through the procedure with the actual values at each step.

Features. Every manuscript is represented twice (Salton and Buckley, 1988). The word space holds tf-idf weights of normalised word forms and stands for *what* is written; the sign space holds tf-idf weights of sign n-grams (n = 1–3) within words and stands for *how* it is written. The main model concatenates both. Weights are sublinear, rows are L2-normalised, and features found in fewer than two manuscripts are dropped. KBo 41.22 has 33 legible words, which yield 177 non-zero features out of 25,372.

Assignment and abstention. Each tradition is represented by the normalised centroid of its manuscripts, and a fragment is scored by its cosine similarity to every centroid. It is placed in the most similar tradition when its lead over the runner-up, the *margin*, reaches a threshold τ, and is left unplaced otherwise. We choose τ on held-out data rather than by hand: manuscripts with at least 40 words (at most 40 per tradition) are held out in turn and cut into ten random windows of $k \in \{3, 5, 8, 10, 17, 25, 40\}$ words, and τ is the smallest margin at which these windows reach 80% precision. This gives $\tau = 0.018$ (90% bootstrap interval 0.018–0.019). KBo 41.22 is closest to the Luwian rituals (0.39) and next to the Kizzuwatna rituals (0.25); its margin of 0.14 is well above τ, and so it is placed. The placement depends on the reference set, however: once every legible manuscript is used, including those without word analyses (Section 5.2), its margin falls to 0.010 and it is not placed. We keep it as the example because it shows each step clearly, and because it shows how thin the evidence of a small fragment can be.

Decomposing a decision. Because the score is a dot product, the margin splits exactly into one term per feature, $x_f(c_{\text{top},f} - c_{2,f})$, where x is the fragment and c the two centroids. Summing these terms by word category or layer shows what a placement rests on, and listing the largest ones gives the words a philologist can check (Figure 1, panels 5–6). This matters because similarity and decision differ: common words such as *nu* make up much of a fragment's similarity to every tradition but little of the difference between two.

Validation. Validation is leave-one-manuscript-out: each reference manuscript is removed from its own centroid (in closed form) and reassigned. We report accuracy and per-tradition recall against two baselines, always guessing the largest tradition (majority) and the same procedure with shuffled labels (200 permutations, which also give a p-value). Idf weights are fitted on the whole reference set.

Layers and word categories. To separate cultural content from scribal habit, the word space is split

into layers, each evaluated alone: logograms, Hittite vocabulary, foreign-language words (Hurrian, Luwian, Hattian, Palaic), and the 392 words attested in more than one spelling, once with their spelling kept and once collapsed to the normalised form. If spelling carried tradition beyond the word itself, the first would beat the second. We also use the word categories of Gordin et al. (2025, Table 4): agents, deities, function words, foreign words, realia and verbs, with realia narrowed to physical things and the remaining nouns grouped by meaning (places; animals, body parts and nature; abstract nouns; adjectives; measures).

No word was classed by hand. Fixed rules derive each category from what TLHdig's editors recorded for the word, applied in order: its determinative (DINGIR makes a deity, ^{LÚ} an agent), its language tag, and its selected morphological analysis (a person-marked form is a verb, a particle or pronoun a function word); unanalysed words fall back on the editors' choices for the same form elsewhere. Nouns and adjectives are then classed by their German gloss, through a list of 5,494 glosses that was drafted with a language model and has not been checked by hand; it is the one step not derived from the editors' records. Each label carries the confidence of the rule that set it: 63% of the 320,638 legible words are classed with high confidence, 25% with medium and 12% with low. A domain expert checked a stratified sample of 178 words: 93%, 88% and 70% were correct at the three levels, 89% overall when weighted by corpus shares. Fixing the 5 rules that the errors pointed to raises the overall figure to 94%, an upper bound since it is measured on the same sample. The audit scored all nominal words as one class, so it does not cover the split by meaning.

5 Results

[Next drafts.]

5.1 Testing scholarly groupings

[Composition recovery and the Ambazzi rituals.]

5.2 Spellings only, with every manuscript

The gap in the annotation falls on the smallest traditions. We therefore repeat the leave-one-out evaluation in the sign space alone, where every legible word counts, once with the analysed manuscripts only and once with all manuscripts of 17 or more legible words (Table 2). The reference grows from 1,625 to 1,897 manuscripts, and overall accuracy stays at 84%. The Luwian rituals grow from 10 to 106 manuscripts and their accuracy from 40% to 86%; the western rituals from 11 to 35 (55% to 83%). The other traditions change little. Of the 847 orphans the main model places, 635 are also placed with the full reference and 608 of these keep their tradition; 37 move to the Luwian rituals and 16 to the western rituals. The worked example is affected: with the full reference KBo 41.22 still points first to the Luwian rituals, but its lead (0.010) falls below the margin, and it is no longer placed. Placements in the two small ritual traditions should be read with this in mind.

	analysed only		all manuscripts	
Tradition	n	acc.	n	acc.
Arzawa (western) rituals	11	55%	35	83%
Hattian cult layer	479	95%	527	93%
Kizzuwatna rituals	165	92%	234	92%
Kizzuwatna and Lower Land (Hurr.)	318	82%	323	79%
Ištanuwa and Lallupiya festivals	52	83%	55	78%
Luwian rituals (Lower Land)	10	40%	106	86%
Mixed (Hurr., Syr., Luw.)	200	67%	206	68%
Palaic festivals	34	82%	36	81%
Syro-Mesopotamia (Hurr.)	167	67%	175	67%
Ḫuwaššanna festivals	189	90%	200	88%
All	1,625	84%	1,897	84%

Table 2: Spellings only: leave-one-out accuracy per tradition in the sign space, with the reference limited to manuscripts that have word analyses, and with all manuscripts of 17 or more legible words.

5.3 What a placement rests on

[Decision split by word category and layer.]

5.4 Duplicates, not joins: a negative result

A fragment's nearest manuscripts are leads for the philologist, and the question is what kind of lead they are. Against the Konkordanz, the ranking finds duplicates: of 212 recorded duplicate pairs, the partner ranks first in 91 and among the 20 nearest of 18,490 manuscripts in 165 (median rank 2). Of the 11 suspected joins, only 3 reach the top 20 (median rank 134). Two pieces of one tablet share their context but, as a rule, not their text, so we tried to learn a ranking for joins.

TLHdig marks on every line of a joined text the

	top 1	top 5	top 20	median rank
Similarity ranking	11%	30%	48%	24
Join model (re-ranking)	13%	32%	51%	9

Table 3: Finding the other piece of a known join: share of 2,335 pieces whose partner ranks in the top 1, 5 and 20, and its median rank, tested on compositions not used in fitting.

piece it is preserved on. Splitting its joined texts back into their pieces gives 2,335 query pieces from 897 joins, each to be found among 19,821 units. A logistic regression re-ranks the nearest candidates of each piece over twelve pair features: similarity, the similarity of the two units' profiles over traditions and over compositions, word and phrase overlap, the share of shared words spelled alike, the distance of their orthographic rates, the overlap of their preserved sides and columns, the same publication volume, the same excavation series, and size. It is tested on compositions it was not fitted on (five folds grouped by CTH number). The gain is small (Table 3): the partner reaches the top 20 for 51% of pieces, against 48% for similarity alone, although the median rank falls from 24 to 9. On the Konkordanz's suspected joins the model places 4 of 10 in the top 20, against 3.

The weights show why. Similarity (+0.85) and the shared tradition and composition profiles (+0.49, +0.58) favour a join, as do identical spellings (+0.20) and preserved columns (+0.23); word overlap counts against it (−0.26), a weak sign of the expected complementarity. The scribal rates have no measurable effect (−0.07, 95% interval −0.16 to 0.02). The joins already made are those scholars could see, mostly pieces that share text, so they teach a model what duplicates look like. Find spot and date, the evidence one would want, cannot be fitted honestly, because for known joins the Konkordanz often derives them from the join itself. Text alone, we conclude, finds parallels and duplicates but does not tell a join from them; that needs physical evidence.

6 Discussion and conclusion

[Genre before origin; QTM in one paragraph.]

Limitations

[Uneven editions, small traditions, the unchecked gloss list.]

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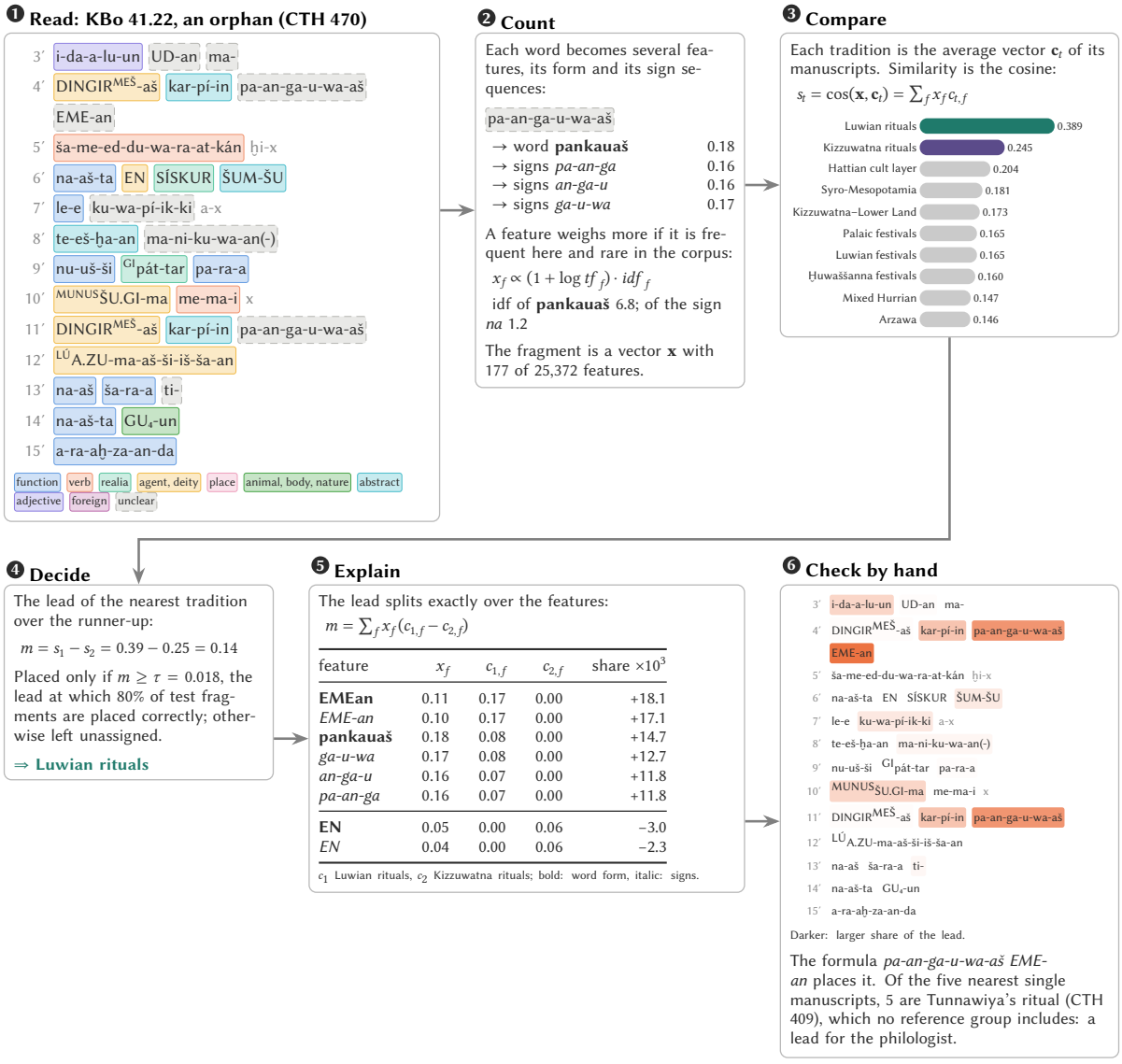


Figure 1: The worked example: the orphan KBo 41.22 (filed under CTH 470 in TLHdig 0.3) from its text to its placement. (1) The legible words, tinted by word category (dashed: a low-confidence or unclear class). (2) Each word becomes a word-form feature and sign-sequence features, weighted by tf-idf. (3) Cosine similarity to the centroid of each tradition. (4) The lead of the nearest tradition over the runner-up, against the calibrated margin. (5) The lead split over the features that make it. (6) The same split on the text, and the closest single manuscripts as leads for the philologist. All values are generated from the experiment outputs.